What Is Human Leadership?

Conscience, Character and Ten Qualities of a True Leader

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Abstract

This essay is the author's personal reflection on what true leadership is, drawn from years of working under and alongside many different leaders, and of leading in practice himself. It starts from a simple claim: before anyone can lead others, they must first be *human*, in the sense of listening to the conscience within. From there it defines *leadership* as the ability to make right but difficult decisions under enormous stress, and describes ten qualities that true human leaders share: (1) how they think, (2) how they hope, (3) how they decide, (4) how they act, (5) how they stay calm, (6) how bold and honest they are, (7) how they manage pace, (8) how they navigate the greys of the real world, (9) what kind of politics they play, and (10) whether they leave new leaders behind them. It arrives at a single conviction: *the first person every leader has to lead is themselves*.

1 Why Write About Leadership?

Everyone who has worked for a while carries a private list of the leaders they have known. A few names on that list are remembered with gratitude, long after the projects themselves are forgotten; most of the others slowly fade. As my own list grew, I noticed that what set those few apart was not intelligence, technical skill or title. These certainly matter—they sharpen a leader's judgement and earn the team's respect—but they alone did not decide who was remembered with gratitude. What decided it was how a leader behaved in the hard moment: when the pressure was high, the facts were incomplete, the fear of failure was building up, and the right decision came at a personal cost. In such moments, some stayed calm, honest and fair to themselves, to their people and to their organisation; others turned defensive or self-serving, or simply stepped aside. That behaviour, far more than any skill, is what people remembered. Behind that behaviour, I came to believe, lay one thing: whether the leader listened to their conscience and acted on it. Those who did had first learned to lead themselves, and only then led others.

This essay is my attempt to describe that difference: what it means to be human first, what leadership really asks of a person, and the ten qualities I have come to see in the leaders worth remembering. It is written for anyone who leads, or hopes to lead—whether a team of two or an organisation of thousands—and for anyone who has wondered why some leaders earn lasting respect while others do not. I have not tried to survey the enormous literature on leadership, and I cite only a handful of sources. What follows comes from more than two decades of my own experience, and from reflecting on it. Where an old idea—from the Upaniṣads, the Bhagavad Gītā, or the great writers gathered in *Light from Many Lamps*, for example—says something especially well, I borrow it. Otherwise, the thoughts—and the responsibility for them—are my own.

2 First, Be Human

I want to begin by drawing a firm boundary. This essay is about *human* leadership, and I leave out non-human leadership entirely, because I do not believe true leadership can exist without humanity.

By "human" I do not mean the biological species. I mean something closer to the Hindi word *insāniyat*, or the Kannada word *mānavīyate*: humaneness. Put simply:

Human

A person is **human** when they recognise the inner, invisible and very powerful presence within them—which Hindu philosophy calls the *ātman*, and which we might also call conscience or an inner voice—and when they **make decisions and act according to what it quietly tells them**.

The Kaṭha Upaniṣad has an image for this that I find very useful:

> *Know the Self as the owner of the chariot, and the body as the chariot. Know the intellect as the charioteer, and the mind as the reins. The senses are the horses.*
>
> — Kaṭha Upaniṣad 1.3.3–4 (paraphrased)

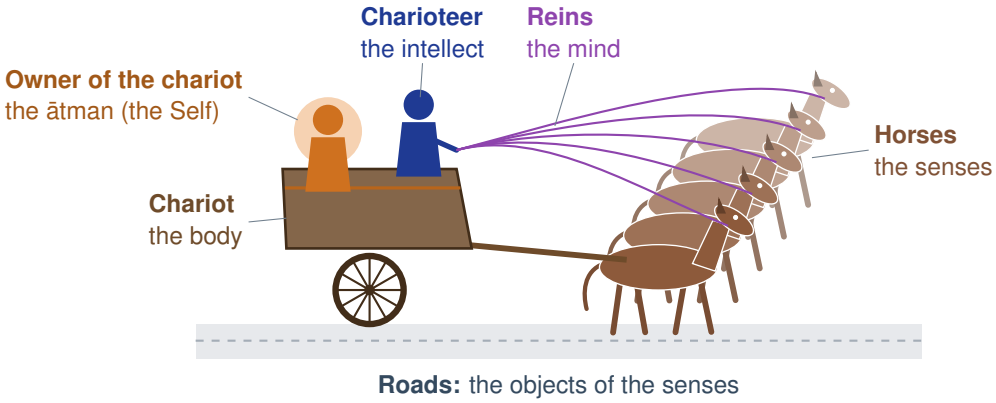


Figure 1: The chariot image from the Kaṭha Upaniṣad. The ātman owns the journey; the intellect steers; the mind holds the reins; the senses pull. Trouble begins when the horses, not the owner, decide where the chariot goes.

In this picture (Figure 1), the ātman (the Self) owns the journey. A person stops being human, in the sense I mean, when the horses take over: when fear, greed, ego or the pressure of the moment decides where the chariot goes, and the owner is no longer consulted. Such a person may still be brilliant, powerful and successful. But in my view, whatever they are doing is not true leadership.

This foundation matters for everything that follows. Every quality described later—positive thinking, decisiveness, calm, boldness—can also be used by someone without a conscience. A manipulator can be calm. A bully can be decisive. So the qualities alone do not make a true leader. What makes the difference is *who is in charge of them*: in a true leader, every one of these qualities is guided by the conscience, not by fear, greed or ego.

3 What Leadership Is

With "human" defined, let me now define the second word, "leadership". Put simply:

> **Leadership**
>
> True leadership is the ability to make **right but difficult decisions under enormous stress**, when surrounded by constrained and challenging circumstances.

Each part of this matters. *Right but difficult decisions*: easy right decisions do not need a leader, and difficult wrong decisions are made every day. Leadership lives in the narrow space where the right choice is also the costly one. *Under enormous stress*: what a person says in a calm meeting room tells us little; what they do when time is short, the stakes are high and fear is pulling at them tells us everything. *In constrained circumstances*: no leader ever has as much time, money, authority or information as they would like when making a decision. Waiting for perfect conditions means waiting forever; real leadership is exercised within these limits, not after they disappear.

The Bhagavad Gītā itself opens in exactly this situation: Arjuna, the great warrior of the *Mahābhārata*, standing between two armies, paralysed by a decision that is both right and unbearable. Much of what follows in the Gītā is, among other things, advice on how to decide and act under that kind of stress.

Putting the two definitions together:

> **Human Leadership**
>
> Human leadership is holding on to true leadership **without ever giving up on humanity**, however difficult the situation becomes.

That gives a two-part test for any act of leadership:

- **The leadership test:** was the right but difficult decision made under pressure?
- **The humanity test:** was the conscience heeded while making it?

A person who passes the humanity test but fails the leadership test is the *kind but weak manager*: everyone likes them, but no one can rely on them when it matters. A person who passes the leadership test but fails the humanity test is the *effective but inhuman boss*, who delivers results by treating people as mere tools—to be used, overworked and discarded. True human leadership must pass *both* tests, every time.

4 The Ten Leadership Qualities: An Overview

What does a leader who passes both tests actually look like? Drawing on my own experience, and on what I have learned from books such as *Wings of Fire*, I believe true leadership rests on ten qualities. Here they are, each in a single sentence:

1. **Thoughts.** They guard their thinking and keep it constructive, however noisy and negative the world around them becomes.
2. **Hope.** They hold a grounded belief that the goal can be reached, and keep looking for a way forward when the road is blocked.
3. **Decision Making.** They decide using both facts and a well-trained gut, and accept responsibility for the outcome before they know what it will be.

4. **Focused Action.** They turn decisions into bold, focused action, even when it makes them unpopular.
5. **Calmness.** They stay in control of their emotions under pressure and in success, channelling them instead of letting them burst out or turn into arrogance.
6. **Boldness and Intellectual Honesty.** They stand firm when they are right, and admit it openly when they are wrong.
7. **Knowing When to Hurry and When to Slow Down.** They choose their pace deliberately, and stay even more focused when they slow down.
8. **Idealism versus Reality.** Real situations are rarely black and white. Guided by their ideals, they navigate the greys with tact and smart tactics.
9. **Developmental Politics.** They practise politics that serves the progress of their people and their organisation—growing along with them, never at their expense.
10. **Growing the Next Generation of True Leaders.** They deliberately prepare others to become true leaders—even ones who may one day surpass them.

Why this order?

The order is not arbitrary. The ten qualities fall into four groups, and each group builds on the one before it.

- **The inner cycle (1–4).** These four form a chain. Positive *thoughts* make *hope* possible; without them, hope has nothing to grow from. Thought and hope together give a person the clarity and courage to *decide*. And a decision is worth nothing until it becomes *action*. The results of that action then feed back into that person's thoughts, and the cycle begins again.
- **The stabilisers (5–6).** Pressure can break this cycle at any point, either through emotion or through ego. *Calmness* stops emotion from taking over; *honesty* stops ego from bending the truth.
- **Meeting the world (7–9).** The cycle never runs in a vacuum. A leader must judge the *pace* at which to move, navigate a *reality* that is rarely black and white, and choose what kind of *politics* to practise.
- **The legacy (10).** Finally, a leader is measured by what remains after they have moved on: the *new leaders* they have grown.

Put more simply, qualities 1–6 belong to *the world inside* the leader, and qualities 7–10 to *the world outside*.

These ten qualities are not the whole of leadership, of course. A leader also needs a set of practical skills: communicating clearly, in speech and in writing, and, just as importantly, listening well; learning continuously, so that knowledge keeps pace with a changing world; working well with people, with empathy and an understanding of how others think and feel; delegating and trusting others with real work; handling conflict and negotiating fairly; and adapting when circumstances change. I have not listed these as separate qualities, because they are skills rather than character, and every leader must acquire them anyway. They can be learned from books, courses and experience. Returning to the chariot of the Kaṭha Upaniṣad (Figure 1), these skills are like a well-built chariot with strong wheels—essential for the journey, but they do not decide where the chariot goes. That is still the work of the conscience.

Beneath all ten qualities lies the foundation from Section 2: the ātman, the conscience that every one of these qualities must answer to. Figure 2 brings the whole picture together, and the next

section looks at each quality in turn.

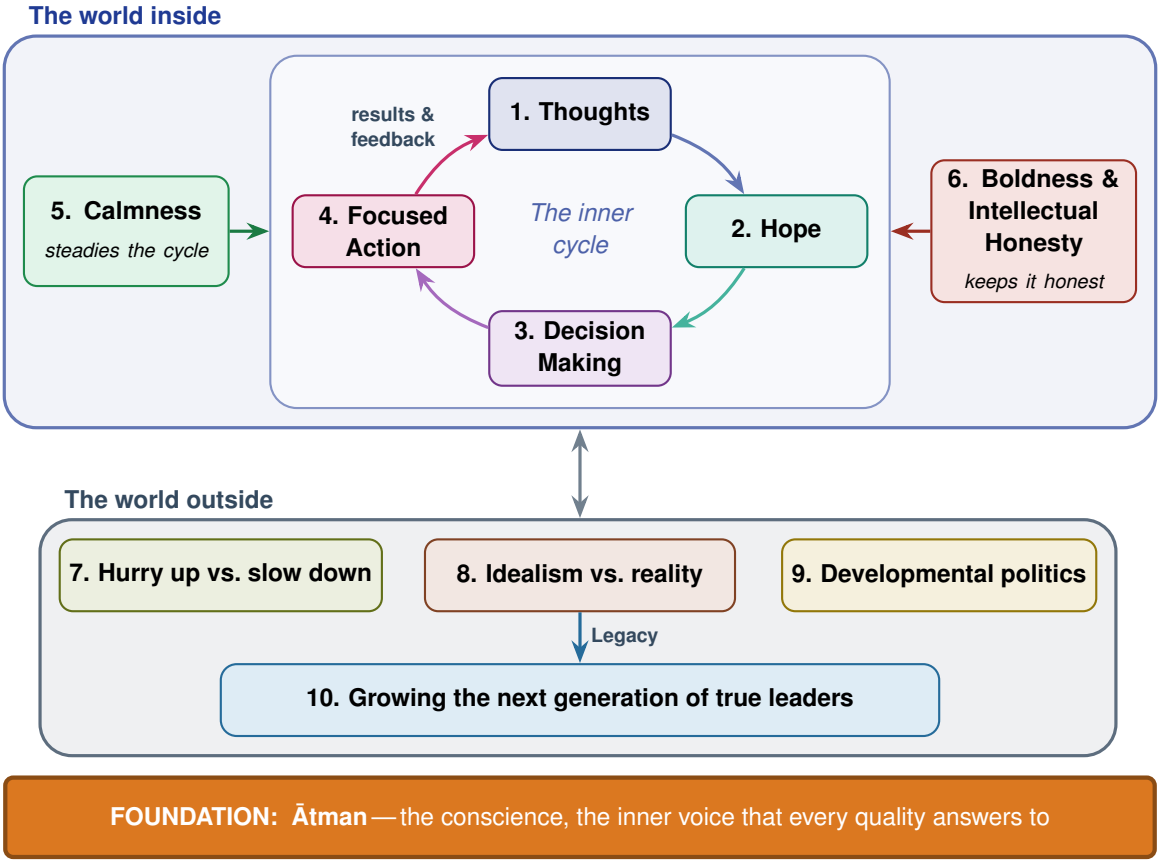


Figure 2: The ten qualities of human leadership. *The world inside* the leader holds the inner cycle (1–4), which turns thought into action, and the two qualities (5–6) that keep it steady and truthful. *The world outside* holds the qualities that govern how the leader meets the world (7–9) and the legacy they leave behind (10). Both worlds rest on a single foundation: the ātman, or conscience.

5 The Ten Leadership Qualities: A Closer Look

5.1 Thoughts

Almost everything about a person begins with their thoughts. Character, behaviour, the words they choose, their temperament, their attitude under pressure, their endurance—nearly every human quality grows out of this one thing. Thoughts make or break a person.

The trouble is that the world is noisy, and today it is noisier than ever, because of all the technology we live inside. My observation is that noise is not neutral. Its nature is to push negativity into our thinking and to slowly drain our positive energy. Think of the endless stream of headlines, messages, social-media opinions and alerts that reaches us every day. Most of it is about problems, conflict and outrage, and very little of it helps us build anything. Spend enough time in that stream, and our own thoughts start to take on its colour.

This is why a leader must build, and protect, a *habit* of positive thinking, however noisy or negative the surroundings become. I do not mean pretending that problems do not exist. I mean choosing carefully what to let into the mind, and, whenever the thoughts start sliding into complaint, deliberately steering them back to a more useful question: *what can I do about this?*

Lillian Eichler Watson's anthology *Light from Many Lamps* gathers this same truth—that we become what we think—from many traditions, as far back as the Upaniṣads: "Man becomes that of which he thinks." James Allen, in his classic essay *As a Man Thinketh*, compares the mind to a garden:

> *A person's mind is like a garden. It may be carefully cultivated or allowed to run wild, but either way it will bring forth. If no useful seeds are planted in it, weed-seeds will fall there on their own, and go on producing their kind.*
>
> — James Allen, *As a Man Thinketh* (paraphrased), in *Light from Many Lamps*

The noise of the modern world is exactly such a stream of weed-seeds.

Recall the chariot of the Kaṭha Upaniṣad (Figure 1). The mind is the reins, and our thoughts are how those reins are held. When thoughts are disciplined, the whole chariot works as it should: the ātman sets the direction, the intellect steers, the mind holds the reins steady, and the horses of the senses pull the chariot where it needs to go. When thoughts are scattered and negative, that same chain breaks, link by link: the voice of the ātman goes unheard, the intellect loses its grip, the mind slackens the reins, and the horses of the senses bolt—dragging the chariot wherever the noise pulls them.

> **In short:** A true leader treats positive thinking as a discipline, not a mood—because every other quality depends on it.

5.2 Hope

Once the habit of positive thinking is in place, the next quality is hope: an optimistic expectation that what one is working towards will turn out well.

Hopelessness paralyses people. It locks up their ability to think creatively, and slowly drags them towards negativity until, in a noisy world, they spiral downward and become complainers about almost everything. I have seen capable people go through exactly this.

I have faced it myself, too. At different phases of my career, hope ran low, and each time I worked my way back, though never quickly or easily. So I write about this quality not as an observer, but as someone who knows from the inside how quietly hopelessness arrives, and what it takes to climb out. The saddest part is that it is contagious: a team takes its cue from its leader, and a hopeless leader soon leads a hopeless team.

So hope is a tonic that has to be taken every day, to keep one's thinking healthy. But it must be *grounded* hope. Believing firmly that things will work out in the end is very different from believing they will work out by next week. The first keeps a person going through a long, hard stretch. The second collapses at the first disappointment. True hope holds on to the outcome while looking honestly at how difficult the present is—and keeps looking for new routes when the old one is blocked.

The actress Mary Pickford captured hope's power to help us recover in a single line:

> *If you have made mistakes, even serious mistakes, there is always another chance for you. . . . This thing that we call "failure" is not the falling down, but the staying down.*
>
> — Mary Pickford, in *Light from Many Lamps*

> **In short:** A true leader takes hope as a daily tonic—faith in the outcome, with eyes wide open to the present.

5.3 Decision Making

With positive thoughts and grounded hope in place, a person is nearly ready to decide—and to decide rightly, most of the time. What is still needed is the courage to live with the possibility of being wrong.

Difficult decisions are, of course, built on facts. However, in my experience, the deciding factor is rarely the hundredth fact; it is the gut: something inside that cannot be fully explained with logic, but that pushes firmly towards one choice. Because the gut plays such a large part in hard decisions, a true leader should trust it and weigh it seriously alongside the facts, rather than hiding behind a pile of data.

But not every gut feeling deserves the same trust. The more real experience lies behind it, the more it can be relied upon. In a seasoned person, a gut feeling is years of experience compressed into a single moment of judgement. In a beginner, what feels like a gut feeling is often just a personal preference in disguise. Part of a leader's wisdom lies in knowing, honestly, which of the two they are listening to in a given situation.

There is one more thing a leader must settle *before* deciding, not after: what they will do if the decision turns out to be wrong. Every difficult decision carries a real chance of failure. A leader who has faced that possibility in advance—accepted the risk, thought about how to recover, and resolved to own the result—can decide with a clear head. The Bhagavad Gītā captures this attitude beautifully:

> *Your right is to the action alone, never to its fruits. Act without clinging to the result, and remain the same in success and failure. That evenness of mind is yoga.*
>
> — Bhagavad Gītā 2.47–48 (paraphrased)

As I understand it, this does not say "do not care about results". It says: do not let fear of the result bend the decision. A leader who has already made peace with possible failure is free to choose what is right, rather than what is merely safe.

> **In short:** A true leader decides with facts and a trained gut, and owns the outcome before knowing what it will be.

5.4 Focused Action

However positive, hopeful and good at deciding a person is, without strong and deliberate action they are no more useful than someone with none of those qualities. Action is what turns leadership from theory into practice. It is where plans start moving towards the goal, and it is how leadership is actually measured.

For a true leader, the right action is very often a bold and difficult one. It can bring enormous pressure, and it can make the leader unpopular with everyone around them. A leader must be ready and willing to be disliked by the whole world when they sincerely believe their action is right. Ralph Waldo Emerson put it plainly:

> *What I must do is all that concerns me, not what the people think.*
>
> — Ralph Waldo Emerson, *Self-Reliance*, in *Light from Many Lamps*

A leader's actions also carry a weight that ordinary actions do not. The Bhagavad Gītā observes:

> *Whatever a great person does, others follow. Whatever standard they set, the world pursues.*
>
> — Bhagavad Gītā 3.21 (paraphrased)

So a leader's actions are never just work; they are instructions to everyone watching.

Action must also be *focused*. Focus means saying NO to thousands of things in order to say YES to a very few. A leader who agrees to everything has, in effect, decided nothing. Henry David Thoreau's two-word advice says the same: *"Simplify, simplify."*

> **In short:** A true leader is measured by action: bold enough to be disliked, and focused enough to say no to almost everything.

5.5 Calmness

Staying calm in a storm needs real emotional agility, and that is much easier to say than to do. People differ widely in how much pressure they can take before negative emotions take over. But here the rule is harsh: *the moment leaders lose control of their emotions, they stop being leaders*, at least for that moment.

So a leader must learn to handle the stress that life brings. Calm does not mean feeling nothing. It means channelling what one feels into something useful, instead of bursting out in a way that damages oneself and everyone nearby. Suppressed emotion tends to explode later; channelled emotion becomes energy.

One truth about this has stayed with me for a very long time: the difference between an energetic person and a confused one lies mostly in how their minds process the same experiences. I first met it in A.P.J. Abdul Kalam's autobiography, *Wings of Fire*, which I read several times in early 2002 as a master's student (the first page of my copy, autographed by Kalam himself, appears at the end of this essay). I returned to that truth again and again. But reading a truth as a student is very different from living it. In my professional life, my instinct under pressure was often to hold my emotions in rather than to channel them, and experience taught me exactly what I wrote above: held-in emotion does not disappear; it waits for the next moment of pressure. So what I write about this quality is not theory. It is a lesson I first read in a book, and then learned in practice.

What I have learned since is simple to say and much harder to do. Between a feeling and the words that leave our lips, there is always a small gap—sometimes only a moment long. Our awareness of ourselves is what fills that gap. If I notice the emotion rising, I can pause, and in that pause I can choose my words instead of letting the emotion choose them for me. That pause is where channelling actually happens. It does not come naturally; it is easier said than done, and it takes deliberate practice, again and again. But each time the gap is used well, what might have been an outburst becomes a considered response.

The Bhagavad Gītā's description of the *sthitaprajña*, the person of steady wisdom, is as good a description of this quality as I know:

> *One whose mind is not shaken by sorrow, who does not crave pleasure, and who is free from attachment, fear and anger—such a person is called a sage of steady wisdom.*
>
> — Bhagavad Gītā 2.56 (paraphrased)

In a very different tradition, the physician Sir William Osler gave young doctors, in his farewell address to them, a single word to carry into their careers: *aequanimitas*, equanimity.

> *What is this patience but an equanimity which enables you to rise superior to the trials of life?*
>
> — William Osler, *Aequanimitas*, in *Light from Many Lamps*

Calmness is tested not only by failure, but also by success—and success is often the harder test. Some leaders are grounded and approachable while they are struggling, but their whole attitude

changes once success arrives: they become arrogant and leave behind the down-to-earth nature that earned them respect in the first place. That, too, is a loss of emotional control; the mind is carried away by elation instead of by fear. The Gītā asks for the same steadiness in both. Paul Hamilton Hayne's poem *This, Too, Shall Pass Away* says it simply:

> *Art thou elated? Ah, be not too gay;*
> *Temper thy joy: this, too, shall pass away.*
> *. . .*
> *Do rays of loftier glory round thee play?*
> *Kinglike art thou? This, too, shall pass away!*
> — Paul Hamilton Hayne, *This, Too, Shall Pass Away*, in *Light from Many Lamps*

In short: A true leader channels emotion rather than suppressing it, in failure and in success alike, knowing that an outburst, or arrogance, is never private.

5.6 Boldness and Intellectual Honesty

Neither a self-pitying person nor a dogmatic, opinionated one is a true leader. Nobody is always right and nobody is always wrong. To err is human. What marks a true leader is the boldness to hold firm when they are genuinely right, and the honesty to admit it openly when they are wrong. Shakespeare's advice in *Hamlet* sits at the heart of this quality:

> *This above all: to thine own self be true;*
> *And it must follow, as the night the day,*
> *Thou canst not then be false to any man.*
> — William Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, in *Light from Many Lamps*

Of all the qualities in this essay, this is the one I have lived by most fully, in line with my own conscience. When I strongly believed I was right, I dared to stand firm, against all odds, and set out to prove it. When I had truly failed, I accepted the failure honestly, without excuses. Over the years, this made me a very straightforward person. With time, I also learned that honesty delivered too bluntly can hurt more than it helps. Today I still say things plainly, without any sugar-coating, but with far more care in how I say them. The truth I speak has not changed; only the way I deliver it has.

This quality is also where leaders most easily slip. When reality turns against them, the temptation is to cover it with every kind of sugar-coating—and a leader who gives in to it loses the trust of the very people they are leading. Sugar-coating buys a little comfort today at the cost of all credibility tomorrow. It also teaches the whole team to hide their own mistakes, which is far more dangerous than any single error.

One of the clearest examples I know comes, once again, from A.P.J. Abdul Kalam's life. In 1979, India's first satellite launch vehicle, SLV-3, failed and fell into the Bay of Bengal. Kalam was the project director. At the press conference, ISRO's chairman, Satish Dhawan, faced the media himself and took responsibility for the failure. A year later the launch succeeded, and this time Dhawan asked Kalam to face the press. Kalam later summed it up: when failure came, the leader owned it; when success came, he gave it to his team.

In short: A true leader stands firm when right, admits it when wrong, and never sugar-coats reality—because trust is built on honesty, not on always being right.

5.7 Knowing When to Hurry and When to Slow Down

Constantly hurrying and speeding everything up does not always bring progress. Sometimes a situation forces us to slow down—and occasionally even to step away from the game for a while. A true leader knows when to speed up and when to slow down.

What I find most interesting is that slowing down is harder than speeding up. Speed has momentum, and momentum is a good place to hide from difficult truths. A slow-down removes that hiding place and forces one to face reality. That takes more energy, not less, and it is why a leader must be even more sharply focused during a slow-down than during a sprint.

Longfellow captured both halves of this balance in four lines:

> *Let us, then, be up and doing,*
> *With a heart for any fate;*
> *Still achieving, still pursuing,*
> *Learn to labor and to wait.*
>
> — Henry Wadsworth Longfellow, *A Psalm of Life*, in *Light from Many Lamps*

"Up and doing" is the speed-up; "learn to labor and to wait" is the slow-down. A true leader needs both.

> **In short:** A true leader treats pace as a decision, and knows that a slow-down used for focused reckoning is often the quickest way forward.

5.8 Idealism versus Reality

We often live in a world that preaches idealism but practises something quite different. The line that *should* matter is the one between firmness and harshness, between strong leadership and bullying.

Yet real situations rarely fall neatly on one side of such a line. Most of what a leader faces is not black and white, but shades of grey: interests that pull in different directions, people who are neither heroes nor villains, and choices in which every option carries some cost. Pure idealism struggles here, because it expects the world to be simpler than it is. Pure realism fails too, because it slowly stops asking what is right and settles for whatever works.

A true leader holds both. They keep their ideals as the compass, and use tact and tactics to find a way through the greys. In practice, this means reading people and situations carefully, understanding what each side really needs, choosing which battles are worth fighting, picking the right moment, building allies, and knowing where to compromise and where never to. In this sense, the leader plays their own game—not against others, but for an outcome that is good for everyone involved.

That game is a *positive-sum* one. In a zero-sum game, the pie is fixed, so a bigger slice for one person means a smaller slice for someone else. In a positive-sum game, people work together to make the pie itself bigger, so everyone can end up with more. Much of the skill of dealing with the greys lies in finding that bigger pie: an option in which the people, the organisation and the leader all gain, rather than one side winning at another's cost.

Tactics, of course, can also be used without a conscience. What keeps a leader's tactics honest is a simple rule that Confucius made the centre of his entire philosophy:

> *What you do not wish done to yourself, do not do to others.*
>
> — Confucius, in *Light from Many Lamps*

Tactics that pass this test are wisdom; tactics that fail it are mere manipulation.

> **In short:** A true leader keeps their ideals as the compass, and uses tact and tactics to navigate the greys—always towards an outcome in which everyone can gain.

5.9 Developmental Politics

Like space and time, humans and politics are inseparable. They are woven into each other; you cannot study one without the other.

Wherever people decide things together—with different interests, priorities and points of view—there is politics. It is simply how a group of people finds its way to shared decisions, and like any skill, it can be used well or badly. So the real question for a leader is not whether to take part in politics, but which *kind* of politics to practise. I see two:

(1) **politics for its own sake**, which is centred on the self and on power; and

(2) **developmental politics**, which is centred on the progress of everyone—the people, the organisation and the leader too, but never at the expense of others.

A true leader chooses the second kind, consistently. The tact and tactics of the previous section are the tools of politics; developmental politics is simply using them for everyone's progress.

A simple question tells the two apart. Before any important decision, a leader should ask honestly: *who will benefit from this?* If the honest answer is "mainly me, even at others' cost", it is politics for its own sake. If the answer is "my people, my organisation, and I along with them", it is developmental politics. The two also measure success differently. Power-centric politics counts how high the leader has risen. Developmental politics counts how far the people and the organisation have moved forward—with the leader rising alongside them, not above them.

Abraham Lincoln, closing his second inaugural address near the end of a bitter civil war, showed what developmental politics sounds like even in the hardest of times:

> *With malice toward none; with charity for all; with firmness in the right, as God gives us to see the right, let us strive on to finish the work we are in; to bind up the nation's wounds . . .*
> — Abraham Lincoln, Second Inaugural Address, in *Light from Many Lamps*

> **In short:** A true leader plays politics for the progress of their people and organisation, and grows along with them—never at their expense.

5.10 Growing the Next Generation of True Leaders

The last quality is the one that outlives the leader. A true leader deliberately grooms, encourages and prepares the people around them to become true leaders themselves.

I place it last for two reasons. First, it builds directly on quality 9: developmental politics asks whether people are progressing; this quality goes one step further and asks whether they are progressing all the way to leadership. Second, it is the final test of the other nine. Leaders who are secretly insecure, dishonest or power-centred will not grow successors, because a capable successor is a threat to them. Only a leader who is secure in their own conscience can truly want others to surpass them.

In practice this means giving people real responsibility before they feel fully ready, standing behind them when they stumble, and stepping aside when they succeed so that others can receive the credit and the visibility. The SLV-3 story shows exactly this. When Dhawan sent a

young project director to face the press after the success, he was not only being generous; he was building a leader. That young project director went on to lead India's missile programme and eventually became President of India.

The Gītā verse quoted under Focused Action—whatever a great person does, others follow (3.21)—has a quiet implication here: a leader is always teaching, whether they intend to or not. The only question is whether they are teaching people to lead, or merely to obey.

> **In short:** A true leader is measured not by the followers they gather, but by the leaders they leave behind.

6 Real and Counterfeit

Each of these ten leadership qualities has a counterfeit: an imitation that looks like the real quality from a distance, but quietly undermines it on closer inspection. Forced positivity, for example, can pass for positive thinking, and stubbornness can pass for boldness. The counterfeits are easy to fall into, often without noticing. Any of us—myself included—can practise a counterfeit while sincerely believing we are practising the real thing. Table 1 puts each quality side by side with its counterfeit.

Quality	The real thing	The counterfeit
1. Thoughts	Disciplined, constructive thinking that still sees problems	Forced positivity that refuses to hear bad news
2. Hope	Faith in the outcome, with eyes open to the present	Wishful thinking
3. Decision Making	Facts plus an experienced gut; outcome owned	Impulse dressed up as intuition; blame when it fails
4. Focused Action	Bold, selective, willing to be disliked	Busyness; recklessness; saying yes to everything
5. Calmness	Emotions felt and channelled, in failure and in success	Emotions bottled up until they explode; indifference; arrogance after success
6. Boldness & Honesty	Firm when right, open when wrong	Stubbornness; or constant self-pity
7. Hurry vs. Slow Down	A deliberate, focused change of pace	Panic; or avoidance disguised as patience
8. Idealism vs. Reality	Ideals as the compass; tact and tactics to navigate the greys	Naive idealism that ignores the greys; or tactics without a conscience
9. Developmental Politics	Progress of the people, the organisation and the leader together	Favours and slogans that serve power
10. Next Generation	Growing people who may surpass you	Keeping people dependent; grooming loyalists, not leaders

Table 1: Each quality and its counterfeit.

7 Closing Thoughts

This essay began by drawing a boundary. True leadership, I argued, cannot exist without humanity, and a person is human only when they recognise the ātman—the conscience, the inner voice—and act on what it tells them. In the chariot of the Kaṭha Upaniṣad, that means the owner, not the horses, decides where the journey goes.

On that foundation, I defined leadership as the ability to make right but difficult decisions under enormous stress, and human leadership as holding on to that ability without ever giving up on humanity. The ten qualities describe what this looks like in practice. The inner cycle of *thoughts*, *hope*, *decision* and *action* turns intention into results. *Calmness* and *boldness with honesty* keep that cycle steady and truthful under pressure. The judgement of *pace*, the skill of navigating the *greys* and *developmental politics* decide how the leader meets a world that is rarely black and white. And the *next generation of true leaders* is what remains after the leader has moved on. Each quality has its counterfeit, and the difference between the two is almost always the same: whether the conscience is still in charge.

Titles, followers, results—and even skills—can all be gained without being human. True leadership cannot. It shows itself in the hard moment—under stress, in a noisy world, amid competing interests—when a person listens to their conscience, decides, acts, stays calm, tells the truth, chooses the right pace, navigates the greys with conscience, measures success by the progress of everyone—themselves included—and makes room for the leaders who will come after them.

None of this is easy—if it were, true leaders would not be so rare. I do not claim to have mastered all ten qualities the way Kṛṣṇa does in the *Mahābhārata*. But my experience has given me the clarity and the courage to keep moving steadily in that direction. After all, these qualities are not a finish line but a path: something to keep practising every day, through every success and every setback. Everything I have learned, from my own journey and from seeing leadership at its best and at its worst, comes down to one thing: **the first person every leader has to lead is themselves.**

Sources

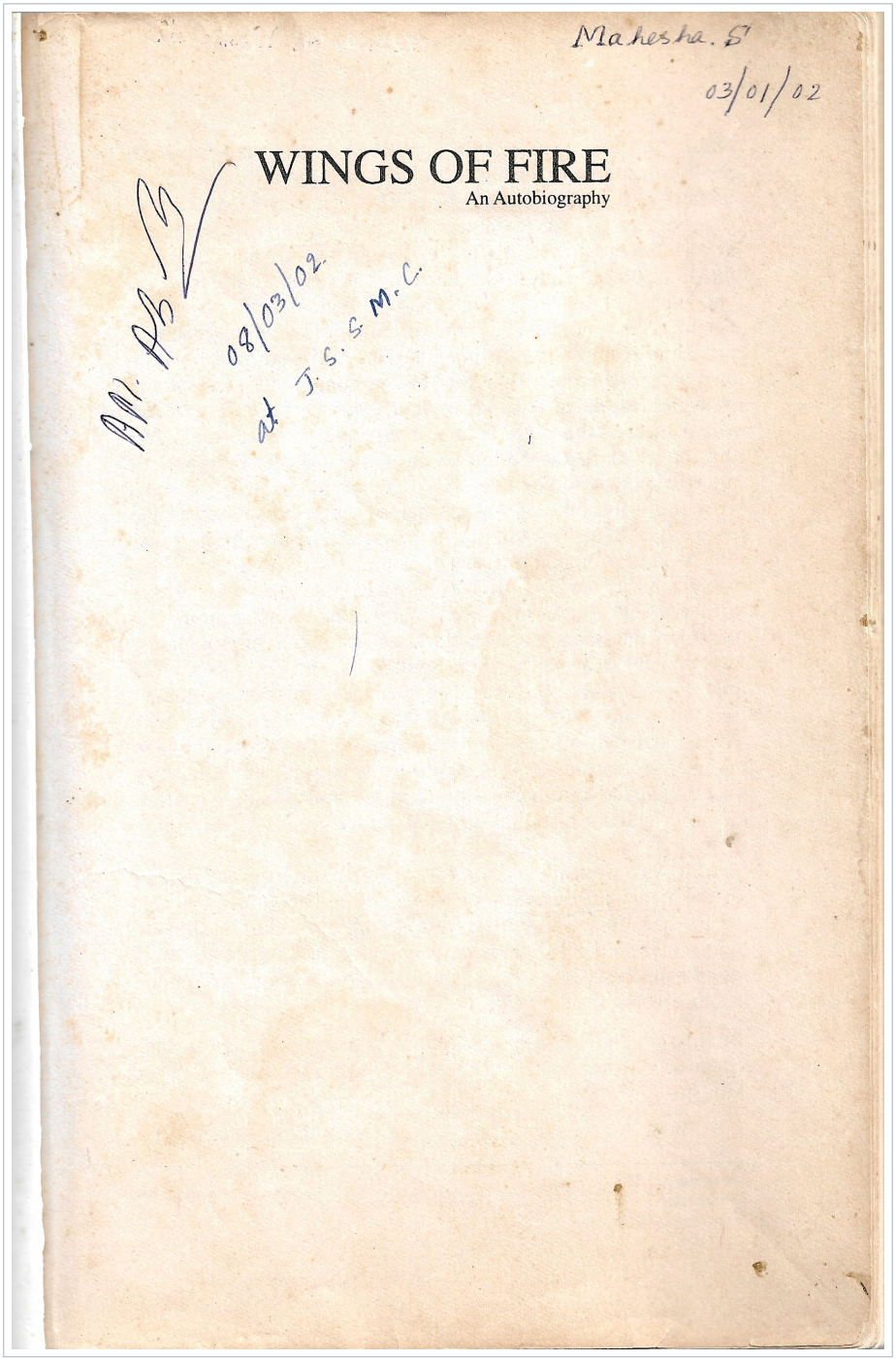
[1] The Kaṭha Upaniṣad (1.3.3–4), in any standard translation.

[2] The Bhagavad Gītā (2.47–48, 2.56, 3.21), in any standard translation.

[3] A.P.J. Abdul Kalam with Arun Tiwari, *Wings of Fire: An Autobiography*, Universities Press, 1999.

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A Page from *Wings of Fire*



The first page of the author's own copy of *Wings of Fire*, autographed by Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam on 8 March 2002, when he visited Mysore to address the graduation convocation at JSS Medical College.